Children of Cambodia's Killing Fields

By Dith Pran and Kim DePaul (eds)

INTRODUCTION

Youkimny Chan's story is one of millions. Every day, somewhere in the world, someone is struggling to survive genocide, oppression and hopelessness. Children watch their families die around them on a daily basis. They are left with a lifetime of pain, suffering and healing.

Youkimny Chan was sponsored in 1980 by Catholic Social Services in Minnesota. He received an education in the states following the Khmer Rouge and is now a social worker in Long Beach, California.

It's time for us to wake up. It's time to start really seeing what is going on in the world – outside our circle of complacent comfort. It's time to fight for those unable to fight for themselves.. It's time for peace to be restored. Bring truth. Bring life. Give hope. Show grace. Heal the world.

What follows is an excerpt from Children of Cambodia's Killing Fields, edited by Dith Pran and Kim DePaul – it is a collection of memoirs by child survivors. This is Youkimny Chan's story.

When I was just a little boy I would sit with my sister Sinuoen in our swing under a coconut tree. She would read stories to me about amazing places. We would talk and sing songs together and sometimes listen to soap operas on the radio. I loved my sister and I loved those happy times we spent together. In the evenings we would sit under the full moon and listen to the crickets and the coconut tree leaves rustling in the breeze. We would talk about what we wanted to do when we grew up. It was good growing up in Cambodia.

In the afternoon, while the adults napped, the children would go down to the river to swim. The beaches of the Mekong River were wide and sandy, and the river was blue and sparkling. My friends and I would splash and yell and then run onto the beach and start a game of soccer or hopscotch or volleyball. If we got hungry, there were always fruit trees nearby, heavy with mangos, coconuts, and bananas. The Cambodia I knew as a child was a beautiful place. Things grew quickly there. Hibiscus and roses of all colors filled the air with fragrance. My grandmother would bring armfuls of flowers into our house every day.

We lived in a garden. When I close my eyes I can still see the blue skies and the tropical flowers. I can still see the laughing faces of my friends and family.

My family was very close. My father, who was a captain, in the Cambodian army, had died of malaria when I was three years old, but my grandparents took me, my mother, and my brothers and sisters to live with them. They became my second parents. I always thought of my grandfather as my real father. Although he was gone often, when he was at home he made time for his grandchildren. I respected him and loved him deeply. My mother was a professional nurse and was very respected by people who knew her.

My oldest sister, Sinoy, was already married and had three children. My brother, Kimhour, who was seven years older than I, was a student at the University of Cambodia and a well-known soccer player. My favorite sibling was Sinuoen, who was five years older than I. She was always patient with me. The youngest in my family was my little brother, Sombo. With my grandparents, we lived in a very large house that had been in the family for generations. It was a beautiful house and it had wonderful black hardwood floors. My grandmother was so proud of those shiny floors. She waxed them every day with coconut skins, kerosene and candle wax to make them glow.

In 1974, the Khmer Rouge took over all the small villages surrounding Phnom Penh, as my grandfather predicted. Soon after that, the bombing of our city began. When the shelling of Phnom Penh started, we were frightened, but we were also a little relieved. We knew that the war would soon be over. Many people from the small towns around us had fled to Phnom Penh as their villages were attacked and destroyed. Many of them had nowhere to live, and so they slept in the streets.

On April 17, 1975, when I was fourteen years old, the Khmer Rouge army came into Phnom Penh with tanks. A man in a slow-moving car shouting into a loudspeaker ordered all the police and military leaders to put down their guns and surrender. He told all the people to leave their houses. My grandfather didn't want the Khmer Rouge to know he was a military officer for their enemy, so he hid his uniform and weapons. We wouldn't leave the

house. It was our home, and we were free people. We were not about to let anyone tell us to leave.

Then soldiers came to our house with their guns and ordered us to leave. They said we would be gone for only three days, and during that time the Khmer Rouge would clean up the city so that it would be safe for us to return. But the soldiers came again and said that the American B-52 bombers were going to attack the city and that we would have to leave in a hurry or be killed by their bombs. The soldiers assured us that they would defeat the Americans and that then we could return to our homes.

These soldiers were our countrymen. We had no reason not to believe them. They weren't going to let us get hurt. So we packed our car with clothes, some gold and jewelry, and some food. Everyone in my family left together. Some crowded into the car and the rest of us walked. Leaving Phnom Penh was an adventure. Thousands of people were leaving at the same time. The streets and sidewalks were covered with people carrying bags, and cars crept along slowly in the congestion. There was so much noise.

The next day, soldiers came and searched us. They took our jewelry, our car, and most of our clothes. Now everyone in our family had to walk, and we had to divide the remaining food among us to carry it on our backs. It was the dry season and it was very hot. There was no water. People began to get heatstroke and fall down on the road. The soldiers wouldn't let us stop to help those who were sick. I couldn't believe what was happening. We walked for days, then weeks. Pregnant women gave birth under trees by the road. Old people died from exhaustion and lack of water. Everywhere was the sound of babies screaming and people crying for loved ones who had died and had to be left on the road.

There was no time for funerals. Soldiers threw the bodies into empty ponds and kept everyone moving. Guns were pointed at us, and tanks forced us to keep moving. I saw two men with their hands tied behind their backs. Soldiers were questioning them on the side of the road. The soldiers cut off the men's heads, which fell to the ground as their bodies slumped. There was nothing I could do. People were being murdered before my eyes. These

were my friends, my neighbors. The rest of us kept walking.

Finally, after almost two and a half months of walking and stopping, walking and stopping, we arrive outside the province of Battambang, where most of the small villages in the jungle had been burned to ashes during the fighting. We were told that we must live in those burned-out villages. We were civilized people. We had never lived in the jungle without houses and electricity and running water. We still believed that we would be allowed to return home. My grandfather asked the soldiers when we would leave and was told, "In a few days." After many days, I saw him beginning to lose faith.

Our family had to survive even though we had almost nothing. My grandfather, older brother, and brother-in-law built a small hut out of bamboo they cut down. It had a bamboo floor to protect us from snakes and palm leaves for the roof. Thirteen of us lived together in the hut.

All of us started to get sick from malnutrition. Many were getting malaria. There was no medicine and no doctors. Finally we began to eat banana and papaya trees - not the fruit of the trees. We would peel off some layers of the bark, then cut off pieces of the tree and boil them with salt. It gave us something to eat, but it also made some of my family very sick. My sister's ten-year-old son got diarrhea and died after three days of suffering. Then her seven-year-old daughter died. My sister went crazy with grief. She would not move from the spot where we buried them. She never recovered.

After we had been in our hut for about a year, the soldiers came to take my grandfather. They grabbed him and tied his hands behind his back. "We know you were in the military," they said to him. Grandfather did not struggle. But as he left, he turned to my grandmother and said, "Would you take care of my family?" The soldiers slapped him in the face and marched him out. Many minutes went by. We heard a shot deep in the jungle. We knew Grandfather was dead.

The Khmer Rouge continued their killing. If someone was suspected of having an education or of being an intellectual, the soldiers would pull him out of his hut at night and

shoot him or cut his throat. None of us could ask questions or cry out. We were weak and sick. We had no weapons. And if we made the soldiers angry, they would kill us.

Three months after my grandfather was murdered, the soldiers took my brother and brother-in-law. They were tied up and taken two or three miles into the jungle. This time I followed, sneaking through the undergrowth so that no one would see me. I watched as my brothers were forced to dig a large hole while the soldiers held guns to their heads. I remember one soldier saying to the other, "We will save our bullets." Then they took big bamboo shoots and beat my brothers again and again until they were dead. Their bodies were kicked into the hole. Their grave was not far from where my grandfather was killed.

Those who were not murdered by the soldiers were dying a slow death. We traded what little we had been able to hide for food from a government family. An ounce of gold would get us a cup of rice. Soon we had nothing left to trade. We were always hungry. We were always sick. My oldest sister, Sinoy, could no longer talk or move. After about a year of living in the jungle, one of my mother's sisters, who had been living with us, died early in the morning. Sooner after, my other aunt died. We found her body already stiff when we woke one morning. The neighbors helped us bury them but we had no grave makers. So many had been buried around the village that it was impossible to keep track of the burial places. By the next day, we couldn't tell where their graves were.

Within about three months after the deaths of my aunts, my grandmother died, and then my older sister. She had already buried her husband and children, and she had nothing to live for. The rest of us continued to struggle to survive. Whenever we got some food, we would divide it. My mother would always give me part of hers. I was her favorite child, and she wanted me to live. But now my mother was very sick. I was afraid she was dying.

She spoke to me quietly. "Son, if you ever get away from the Communists, go to school. They can take away your possessions, but they can't take your education. They can't take what you know." Soon after that, my mother died. I wanted to die, too. She had always

taken care of me and I had depended on her. Now there was no one to take care of me. Soon my little brother died. The neighbors helped me bury him. Now only my sister and I remained.

My favorite sister, Sinuoen, continued to get weaker and weaker. Her skin was sticking to her bones, and she had lost her long black hair. I think this was the hardest time of all for me. It was my responsibility as the oldest male to protect my sister. My mother would be counting on me. But there was nothing I could do. And one day, as we sat together in the hut, Sinuoen put her head on my lap and said, "Kimny, I don't know if I can live any longer. Can I have a spoon of rice?"

My heart was breaking. It was such a little thing she asked. But we had no rice. I got up and brought her our last cup of water. "Sister," I said, "I have no rice to give you. Drink this water." She looked into my face for a moment, and then she sipped the water. She put her head down on my lap. And then she died.

I don't know why I didn't die, too. I didn't want to live any more. I was so tired and so hungry. I wandered around for months after that begging for a bit of rice from anyone who had some. I never went back to our hut. Sometimes I slept outside. Sometimes I crawled into the hut of another family. But most families had suffered like mine. No one had enough food. No one had hope.

Then the Khmer Rouge decided they needed more young people from the villages to work for them. They took all the teenagers from our jungle village to a concentration camp in the jungle about thirty miles from where my new hut was. I wasn't afraid to go. My family was all gone. I thought, "If I walk and drop dead, I'll drop dead. It's not so bad."

The concentration camp was just a clearing in the jungle. The other young prisoners and I built a makeshift hut with the bamboo we found. We worked from sunrise to sunset, fourteen or fifteen hours a day, in the rice paddies. It was the rainy season, and the work was hard. After a whole day's work we would be fed a few bites of dry fish and a little rice. Then, before we could sleep, the Khmer Rouge would lecture us about how to be good

Communists. They said that Pol Pot was our Angka. Pol Pot was our new family. If any of us found that our parents were not obeying the Communists, we should turn them in.

We could not escape. The camp was encircled by barbed wire, and the thousand or so of us were all afraid for our lives. Sometimes they would pull a boy out of his hut at night and we wouldn't see him again. Sometimes they would take a boy into the jungle and we would hear him scream. Sometimes they would throw the body parts of a boy they had cut apart into the rice paddies as we worked. "Fertilizer," they would say.

When I was about seventeen years old, I remember trying to sleep at night but the sound of bombing in the distance kept me awake. Each night the bombing got closer and closer. We found out later that the Vietnamese were pushing the Khmer Rouge out of our area and up against the Thai border. The Khmer Rouge guards never said anything about the fighting.

Then one day the Vietnamese soldiers entered our camp. At first, we didn't know who they were. But when they began speaking to us, some of the boys recognized their language. We discovered that the Cambodian soldiers had all deserted the camp. The Vietnamese were kind to us but they told us to leave. We had hoped and prayed to leave for years, and now that we had the chance, we realized that we had nowhere to go. I left the camp with Savath, my new friend. We headed toward Battambang and luckily my friend met up with his family. Houses did not have electricity or running water. The hospitals, schools, and markers were closed. Food was still scarce.

When I was eighteen, I felt I had to return to Phnom Penh to see if any of my cousins or friends had survived Pol Pot. My house was more than one hundred twenty kilometers from Battambang, and I didn't know the way. I started walking in that general direction. I got on an old train, got rides on wagons, and walked some more. Eventually I arrived in Phnom Penh. As I entered my old neighborhood, my spirit crumbled. My house was burned and my friends' houses were burned. Everything that had once been so familiar was gone. I knew that my life was changed forever.

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